WEAPONS AND TECHNOLOGY

Q-SHIPS

Special Service Vessels, code-named Q-ships by the British Admiralty, were created in response to U-boat attacks on merchant shipping. The Royal Navy took old tramp steamers and other vessels and fitted them with concealed guns. A U-boat coming upon such a vessel would not waste a torpedo on it, but instead closed with it on the surface. Once the U-boat approached, the Q-ship would unveil its guns and open fire. Manned by volunteers, the Q-ships achieved their first success in July 1915. In the course of the war they sank 14 U-boats. One of their unintended effects, however, was to encourage U-boats to sink any merchant vessel without warning.



U-boat trap
Volunteers man a hidden gun on board a Special Service Vessel or Q-ship.

WORLD WAR I

OTRANTO STRAIT



Date May 15, 1917
Forces Austrians: 3 light cruisers, 2 destroyers, 3 U-boats; Allies: 2 light cruisers, 8 destroyers
Losses Austrians: none: Allies: 2 destroyers, 14 trawlers, 1 supply ship

Location Otranto Strait, off southern Italy

The Allies attempted to block U-boats in the Adriatic by establishing a barrier from Otranto in Italy across to the Dalmatian coast. Consisting of trawlers with steel "indicator nets" to detect and entangle submarines and of minefields, the Otranto Barrage was not especially successful, but the anti-submarine trawlers did present a tempting target for raids by Austrian destroyers. In May 1917 Austrian Captain Miklos Horthy planned a heavier raid using three light cruisers, *Novara*, *Helgoland*, and *Saida*. Leaving the port of Cattaro at nightfall on May, 14 the cruisers reached the barrage around 3:30 a.m. and steamed along blowing hapless Allied trawlers out of the water. Two accompanying destroyers sank an Italian munitions ship and its destroyer escort. Heading for home, the Austrians were pursued by an Allied force including the cruisers *Dartmouth* and *Bristol*. *Dartmouth* and two destroyers succeeded in pounding *Novara* to a standstill and Horthy was badly injured. But reports of the approach of a stronger Austrian force led the Allies to break off the action. On the way back to Brindisi, *Dartmouth* was badly damaged by the lurking submarine U-25 and a destroyer was sunk by a mine. *Saida* towed the crippled *Novara* back to Cattaro. The Allies subsequently abandoned night patrols by trawlers on the barrage. Horthy survived to become an admiral and, eventually, dictator of Hungary.

WORLD WAR I

RAIDS ON ZEEBRUGGE AND OSTENDE



Date April 23, 1918
Forces British: 75 ships; Germans: unknown
Losses British: 5 cruisers, 1 submarine; Germans: unknown

Location Ostende and Zeebrugge, northern Belgium

A bold but over-optimistic operation was planned by Commodore Sir Roger Keyes to block the exits from German submarine pens in occupied Belgium. The main effort was focused on Zeebrugge. The plan was to scuttle three blockships loaded with concrete in the mouth of the Bruges Canal, linking the U-boat pens to the sea. The approach to the canal was protected by batteries on Zeebrugge mole, a stone breakwater. These were to be disabled by a party of seamen and Marines landed on the mole by the cruiser *Vindictive* and two modified ferries. The raid was executed on the night of April 22–23. The attack went badly from the start. *Vindictive* was battered by gunfire and ran against the mole in the wrong place. The landing party could not take the batteries, making it hard for the blockships—the aged cruisers *Iphigenia*, *Intrepid*, and *Thetis*— to reach the canal entrance. With heroic effort two of the them were scuttled as planned, but one sank short of its target. The raid on Ostende was less successful, the blockships failing to reach the harbor entrance. The raids were immensely popular in Britain. Keyes was knighted and 11 Victoria crosses were awarded. But it cost 214 lives and failed significantly to inhibit U-boat operations.



German Imperial naval ensign
Taken from the submarine U-155 when she surrendered at Harwich in 1918 after a career in which she sank 42 ships.



Zeebrugge blockships
Although the Zeebrugge raid did briefly block the route of the U-boats down the Bruges Canal, the Germans simply created a channel to move the U-boats around the sunken blockships at high tide.